THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Beginner

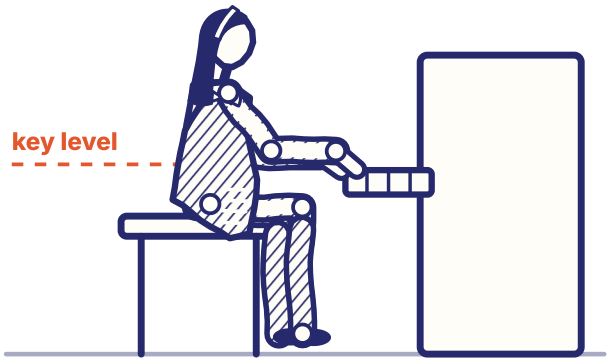
Read it like a storybook: one step on each page, a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. After each room, a page to practise.

THE ROOMS

1 · Sitting and hands
2 · The keyboard
3 · Finger numbers
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · The beat
6 · Notes: crotchet and minim
7 · Notes: three beats and four
8 · Loud and soft
9 · Ear training

Sitting and hands

SCAN TO LISTEN



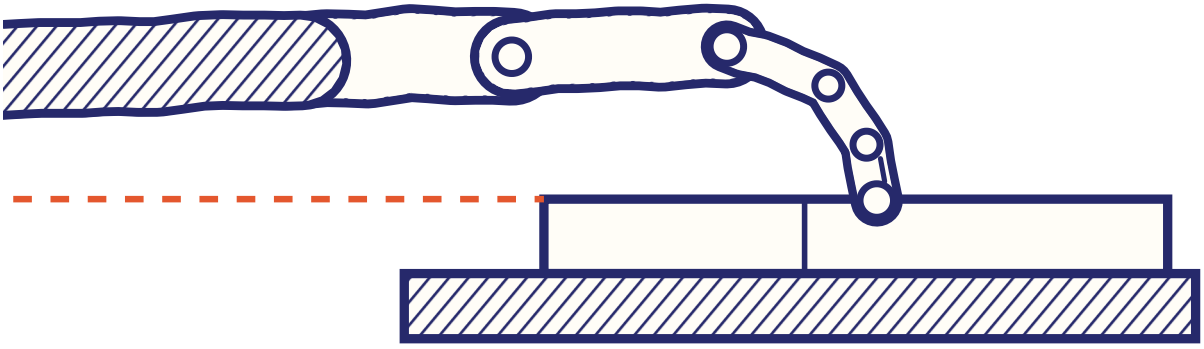
1. **forearms level with the keys**
   wrist neither dropped nor lifted
2. **elbows a little in front of you**
   not pinned to your sides
3. **sit on the front half of the stool**
   opposite Middle C
4. **feet flat on the floor**
   the right foot near the pedal
5. **back tall, shoulders loose**
   lean a little towards the keys

Sit tall on the front half of the stool, with both **feet flat** on the floor.

Your arms float out in front, **level with the keys**, like a table top.

AT THE PIANO

Sit down. Lift your shoulders up to your ears, then let them drop.

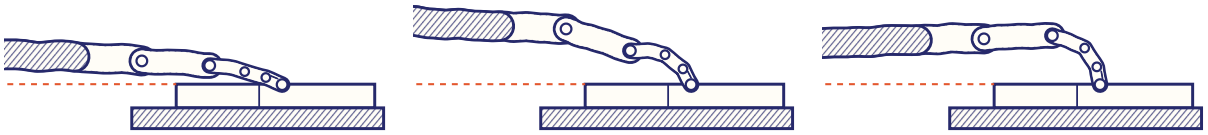


Hold a small ball in your hand. That **round shape** is your playing hand.

Your knuckles stand up like a **bridge**, and you play on your **fingertips**.

AT THE PIANO

Hold a ball or an orange. Put your hand on the keys without changing its shape.



× flat × fallen in ✓ round

A **flat** hand is lying down on the job. A bridge that has **fallen in** cannot carry anything.

The **round** hand can play all day.

AT THE PIANO

Make the flat hand, then the fallen bridge, then the round hand. Feel the difference.

Practise

1 Finger numbers

★☆☆

Write the number of each finger. They are the same in both hands. The first is done.

FINGER	NUMBER	FINGER	NUMBER
thumb	1	ring finger	
index finger		little finger	
middle finger			

2 Too low, too high, or right?

★★☆

Write too low, too high or right.

WHAT YOU SEE	THE STOOL IS
The elbows are well below the keys; the forearms go uphill.	too low
The forearms are level with the keys.	
The elbows are above the keys; the wrists drop down to them.	

3 The 30-second check

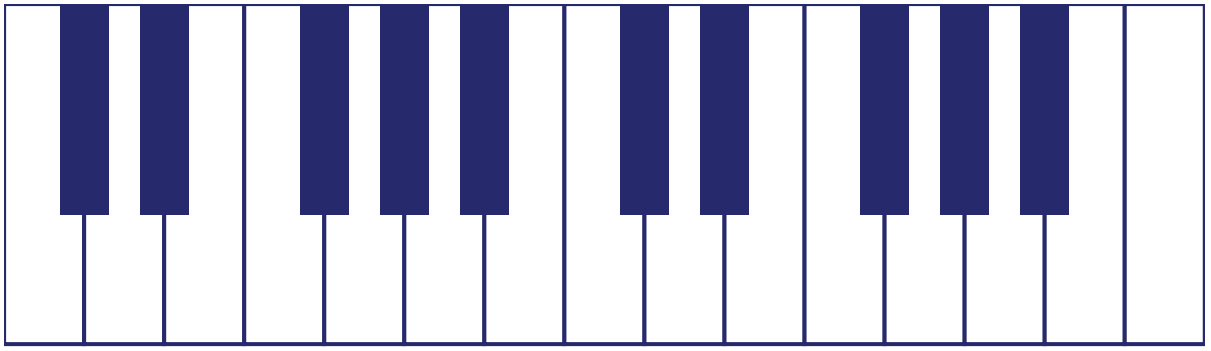
★☆☆

Every time you sit down to practise, check each line and tick a circle. One circle per day.

	MON TO SUN
Stool: forearms level with the keys	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Body: front half of the stool, feet flat	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Shoulders: lifted, then dropped	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Hands: round, knuckles up	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Breathe out, then play	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

The keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN

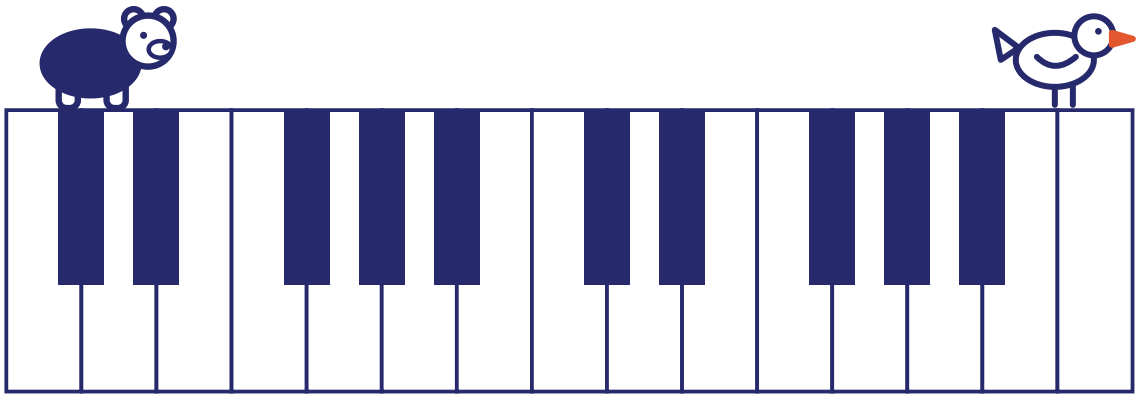


Look at the black keys. They come in **twos** and **threes**, again and again, all the way along.

Find the pattern once and you can never get lost.

AT THE PIANO

Touch every group of two black keys, from the bottom to the top. Then every group of three.



low high

Left is low, like a big grumpy bear. **Right is high**, like a little bird.

Go to the right and every key sounds a little higher.

AT THE PIANO

Play the lowest key you can reach, then the highest. Bear, then bird.



Every white key has a letter. Beside the **two** black keys live **C, D, E**. Beside the **three** live **F, G, A, B**.

After B comes C again: seven letters, round and round.

AT THE PIANO

Find a group of two black keys. Play the three white keys around it and say C, D, E.

Practise

1 Twos and threes

★☆☆

Circle every group of two black keys and every group of three. How many of each?

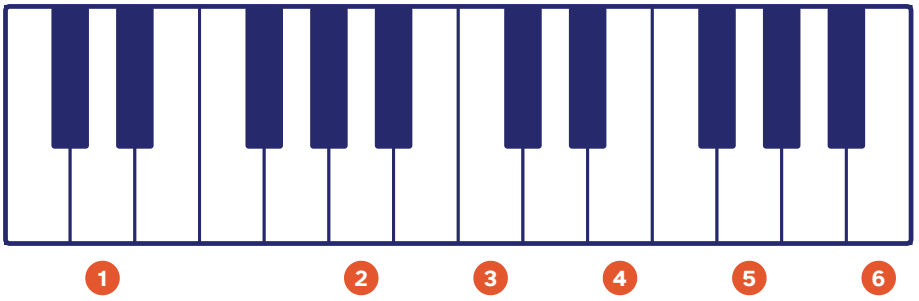


groups of two ☐ groups of three ☐

2 Name the keys

★☆☆

Find the group, then its first key, then walk on. Write the letter name of each numbered key. The first is done.



1 D 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

3 Round and round

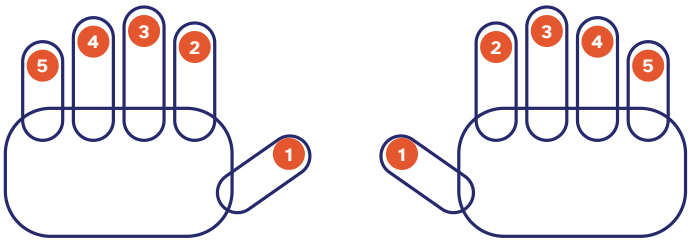
★☆☆

Seven letters, A to G, then A again. Write the next three letters: going up on the left, going down on the right. The first is done.

GOING UP	GOING DOWN
E F G **A B C**	C B A **G F E**
F G A	B A G
A B C	D C B

Finger numbers

SCAN TO LISTEN



Every finger has a **number**. The **thumb is 1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**.

It is the same in both hands: thumbs are always 1.

AT THE PIANO

Hold up both hands. Wiggle finger 1, then 2, 3, 4, 5, saying the numbers.

1	2	3	4	5
C	D	E	F	G

Put your right thumb on C. Now each finger has its own key: **C D E F G** are fingers **1 2 3 4 5**.

One finger, one key. No finger has to jump.

AT THE PIANO

Thumb on C. Play C D E F G and back again, saying the finger numbers out loud.

Practise

1 Five-finger position ★☆☆

Right-hand thumb on C, left-hand little finger on C: write the finger for each note. The first is done.

	C	D	E	F	G
right hand	1				
left hand					

2 Which finger? ★☆☆

Right hand, thumb on C. Write the finger that plays each note. The first is done.

NOTE	E	G	D	F	C
Finger	3				

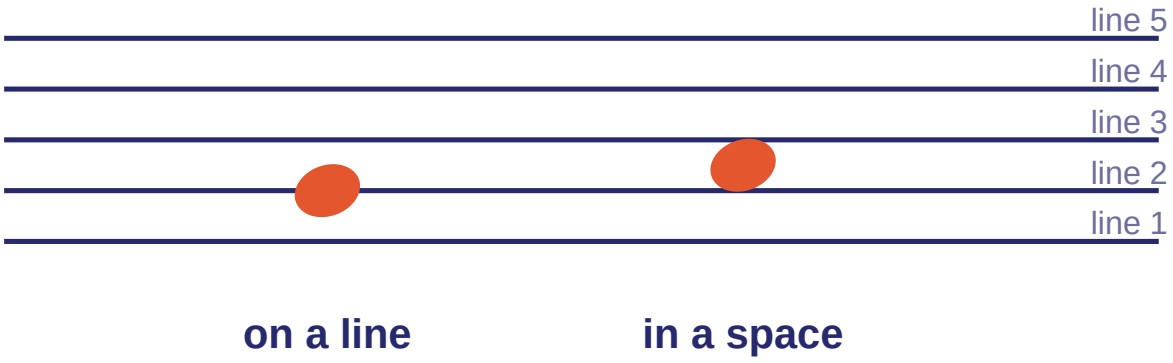
3 Play it ★☆☆

Play C D E F G up and down with each hand, saying the finger numbers. Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

The staff and the clefs

SCAN TO LISTEN



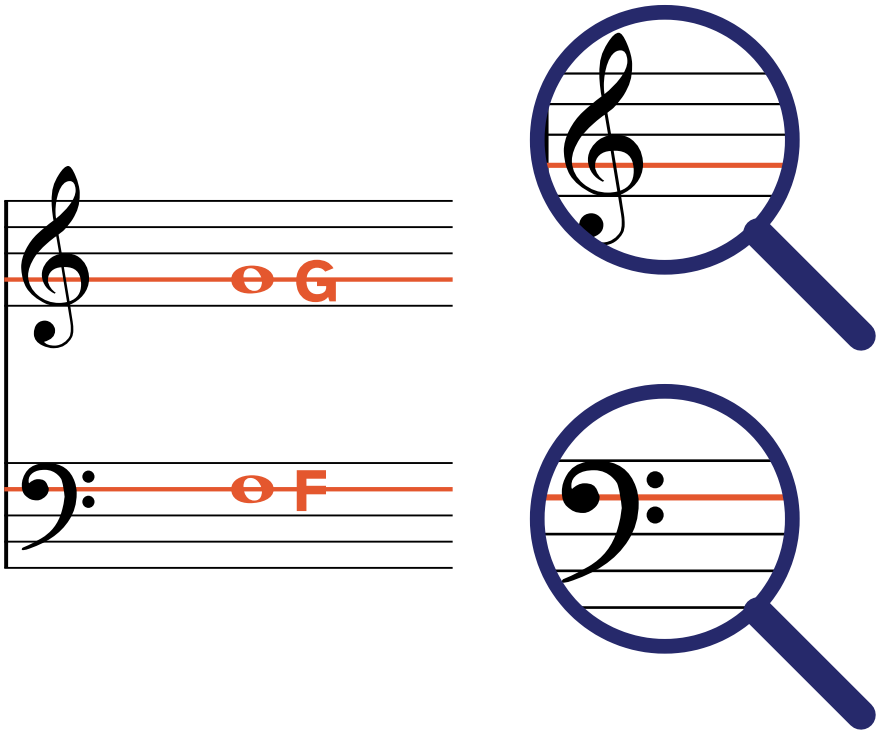
on a line **in a space**

Music is written on **five lines**, called the **staff**.

A note sits **on a line**, with the line through its middle, or **in a space** between two lines. Higher on the staff means higher on the piano.

AT THE PIANO

Count the lines from the bottom: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. Then count the four spaces.



Treble clef = G clef
curls round line 2: G

Bass clef = F clef
its dots hug line 4: F

A **clef** at the start says which notes the lines stand for.

The **treble clef** is the Queen of the high notes: her curl wraps round the line for **G**. The **bass clef** is the King of the low notes: his two dots hug the line for **F**.

AT THE PIANO

Right hand plays the Queen's notes, high up. Left hand plays the King's, down low. Play one of each.

Practise

1 The clefs ★☆☆

Write the name of each clef and the note it marks.

CLEF	NAME	IT MARKS THE LINE FOR
		
		

2 Line or space? ★☆☆

Circle line or space, then write its number (counted from the bottom). The first is done.

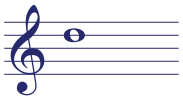


line · space

1



line · space



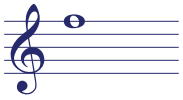
line · space



line · space



line · space



line · space

3 The grand staff ★☆☆

Complete each sentence.

Piano music joins two staves with a _____ .

The _____ staff is on top, usually for the _____ hand.

The _____ staff is below, usually for the _____ hand.

Between them, on a short line of its own, sits _____ .

The beat

SCAN TO LISTEN



Music has a steady **beat**, like a heartbeat. It never speeds up and never stops.

We count the beats: 1, 2, 3, 4, and round again.

AT THE PIANO

Put a hand on your heart. Tap that steady beat on your knee and count 1 2 3 4.



Bar lines put the beats into groups called **bars**. **Beat 1** of every bar is the strongest.

Sometimes a beat is **silent**. You still count it.

AT THE PIANO

Clap three in a bar: STRONG, weak, weak. Then leave out one clap, but keep counting.

Practise

1 How many beats in each bar?

★☆☆

Count the dots between the bar lines. The first is done.



3







2 Add the bar lines

★★☆

Beat 1 is the big coral dot. Draw a bar line just before each one (the first is done).



3 Clap and count

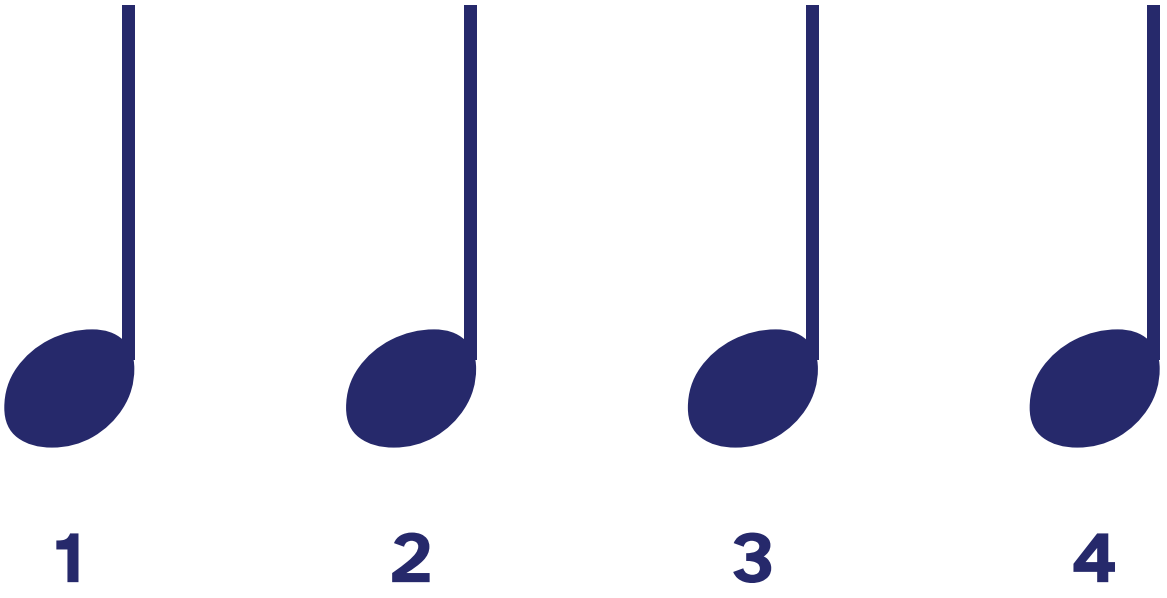
★★☆

Set a metronome to 60. Clap on beat 1, tap your knees on 2, 3 and 4, and count aloud. Keep going for a whole minute. Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Notes: crotchet and minim

SCAN TO LISTEN



This is a **crotchet**. It lasts **one beat**.

Four crotchets fill a bar of four: play, play, play, play.

AT THE PIANO

Play C four times, one for each beat, counting 1 2 3 4.



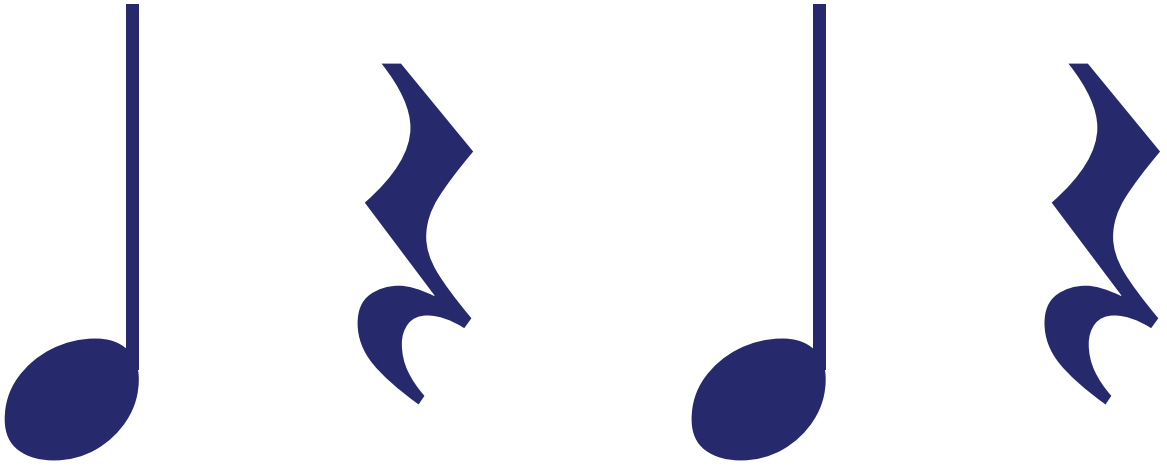
1 – 2 3 – 4

This is a **minim**. Its head is empty, and it lasts **two beats**.

Play on the first beat and **hold** through the second.

AT THE PIANO

Play C as a minim: press on 1, hold through 2. Then again on 3, holding through 4.



play **shh** **play** **shh**

Silence has signs too, called **rests**. A **crotchet rest** is one beat of silence.

You count a rest just like a note. You just do not play.

AT THE PIANO

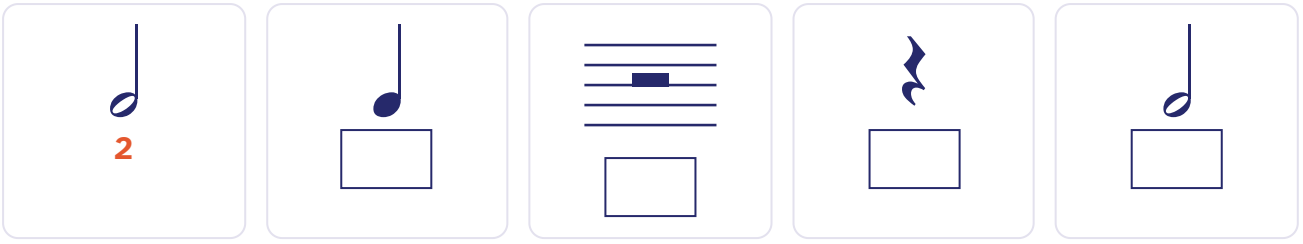
Play, shh, play, shh: C on beats 1 and 3, silence on 2 and 4. Keep counting.

Practise

1 One beat or two?

★☆☆

Write 1 or 2 under each. The first is done.



2 Fill the bar

★★☆

Four beats in each bar. Write the missing note: crotchet or minim. The first is done.



minim





3 Play and count

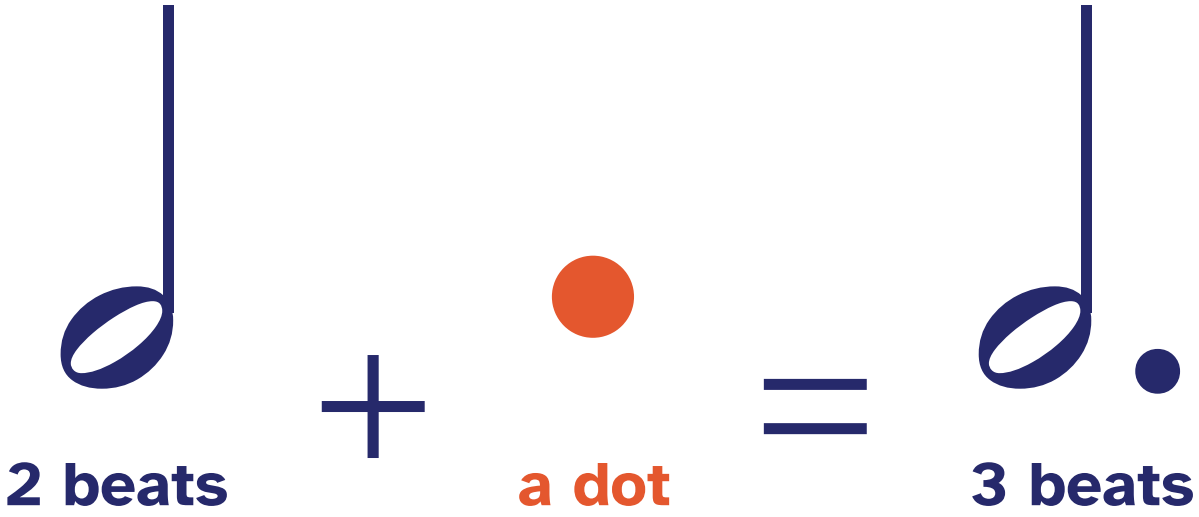
★★☆

Say the counts out loud and play: a crotchet is play, a rest is shh. Write 1 2 3 4 under the bar.



Notes: three beats and four

SCAN TO LISTEN

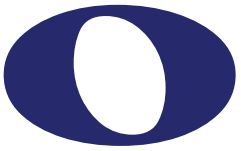


A **dot** after a note makes it half as long again.

A minim is two beats. A **dotted minim** is two and one more: **three beats**.

AT THE PIANO

Play C and hold for 1 2 3. Sway on beat 1, like a waltz.



1 – 2 – 3 – 4

This is a **semibreve**: an empty head and no stem. It lasts **four beats**, a whole bar of four.

Press once, and listen until the sound has had all four beats.

AT THE PIANO

Play C and hold for 1 2 3 4. Lift exactly when the next bar begins.



Now you know the family. Each note is **half** of the one above it.

One semibreve is as long as two minims, or four crotchets.

AT THE PIANO

Left hand holds a semibreve on C while the right hand plays four crotchets on G.

Practise

1 Name, beats and rest ★☆☆

Fill in the table. The first row is done.

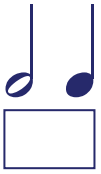
NOTE	NAME	BEATS	ITS REST
	semibreve	4	
			
			
			–

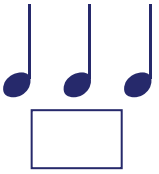
2 Waltz time ★★☆

Each bar has three beats. Count 1 2 3 and play each bar. Write how many notes it has. The first is done.



1





3 Coat or hat? ★☆☆

The semibreve rest hangs like a coat; the minim rest sits like a hat. Write coat or hat.



coat







Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN



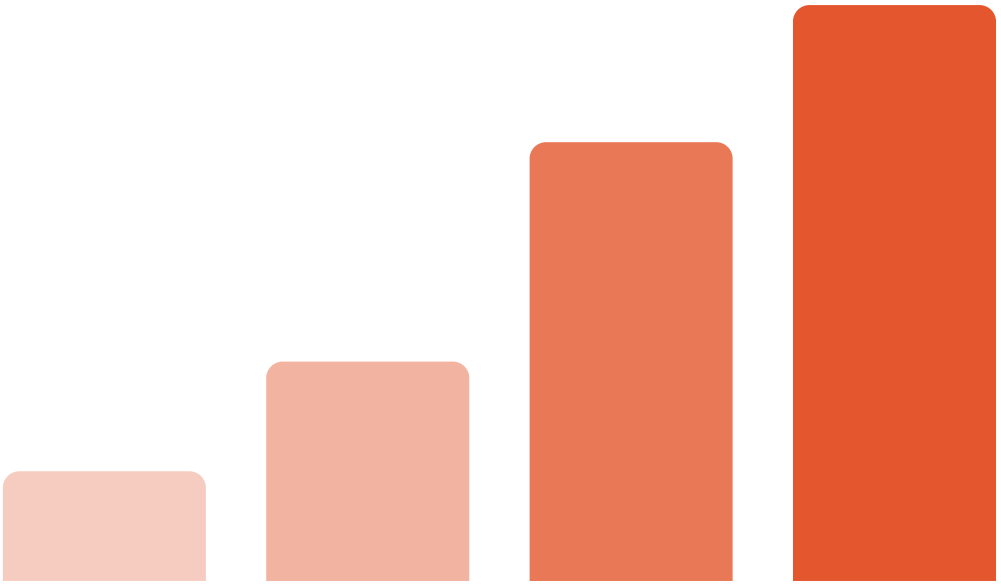
p soft ***f*** loud

Music can be **soft** or **loud**. The signs are Italian: ***p*** for *piano*, soft, and ***f*** for *forte*, loud.

To play louder, let more of your arm's weight into the key. Do not hit it.

AT THE PIANO

Play C softly, like a secret. Then play it loudly, like calling across a field.



pp very soft

p soft

f loud

ff very loud

Two letters mean **very**: ***pp*** is very soft, ***ff*** is very loud.

Soft does not mean slow, and loud does not mean fast. The beat stays the same.

AT THE PIANO

Play C four times: pp, p, f, ff. Four steps, the same speed.

Practise

1 Say it ★☆☆

Write the Italian name and what it means. The first row is done.

SIGN	NAME	MEANS
p	piano	soft
mf		
ff		
mp		
pp		
f		

2 Play it ★☆☆

Play Middle C six times: pp, p, mp, mf, f, ff. Six different steps? Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

3 Which is louder? ★☆☆

Circle the louder sign in each pair. The first is done.

PAIR	LOUDER
p · *f*	*f*
mp · *mf*	
pp · *p*	
f · *ff*	

Beginner · Room 9

Ear training

Listening games before the exams

SCAN TO PLAY

THE SECRET

Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

	GAME	WHAT YOU LISTEN FOR
1	**Low, middle or high?**	Is the sound low, in the middle or high?
2	**Same rhythm or different?**	Two rhythms: the same, or one small change?
3	**Same tune or different?**	Two little tunes: the same, or one note changed?
4	**Which way did it go?**	Three notes: going up, going down, or staying?
5	**Find the note**	Hear a note, then find it on the keys.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Sing before you play.

Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?

Practise

Away from the screen, with a grown-up or your teacher. Tick a circle each time.

1 Floor, tummy or sky? ★☆☆

A grown-up plays one key: very low, in the middle, or very high. Eyes closed! Point to the floor, your tummy or the sky.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

2 Copy-cat clap ★☆☆

A grown-up claps four beats. Clap it back exactly. Then swap: you clap, they copy. Was it the same?

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

3 Stairs up, stairs down ★☆☆

A grown-up plays three keys next to each other, going up or going down. Show the way with your hand, then sing it.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○